

Nine cold call openers.

The complete guide to opening a cold call, with nine scripts and the protocol for finding which one works on your market. Ordered by how much preparation each one takes, not by a ranking nobody measured.

THE FIRST THIRTY SECONDS

0-10s The opener Not a pitch, not a qualification, not a close. One job only.	10-20s The twenty seconds it buys The only thing an opener earns. Your reason for calling lands here, not in the first breath.	20-30s Still talking Still on the line at thirty seconds is the number that decides which opener wins.
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01
It buys twenty seconds

An opener does not book a meeting, qualify or pitch. Holding that spec is what stops you cramming everything into the first breath.

02
Tone is the larger half

A good opener in an anxious voice fails. A mediocre one delivered unhurried often works. Page five is how to fix that in two weeks.

03
Then find your own

Nine openers is nine hypotheses. The test protocol turns them into an answer for your market, your voice and your buyer.

NINE SCRIPTS, THREE TIERS, ORDERED BY PREPARATION

TIER ONE · NO PREP Run at volume today Three openers that work on any tightly segmented list without researching the individual.	TIER TWO · 10 MIN One segment insight Three openers where ten minutes of prep covers a hundred calls, because the context fits the whole list.	TIER THREE · 2-3 MIN EACH Per-prospect research Three openers reserved for accounts genuinely worth the time.
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CATEGORY

Cold calling, outbound, phone technique

LENGTH

13 pages, 9 scripts, 1 worksheet

INTRODUCTION

The first thirty seconds decide the call

Not the pitch, not the discovery questions, not the close. If the opener does not keep them on the line, nothing downstream exists.

Most sellers get this wrong in the same way: they open with themselves.

The standard failure, word for word:

"Hi, my name is James from Northfield Solutions."

WHAT HAPPENS 01

They hear an unfamiliar name

An unknown name and company, first thing, with no reason attached to either.

WHAT HAPPENS 02

They start working it out

Should I recognise this person? While they are doing that, they have stopped listening.

WHAT HAPPENS 03

Your reason has gone past

By the time they conclude they do not know you, your reason for calling is already behind them.

THE WHOLE SPECIFICATION

An opener does not book a meeting. It does not qualify. It does not pitch. It buys you the next twenty seconds.

THE FOUR JOBS PEOPLE GIVE AN OPENER. THREE OF THEM ARE NOT ITS JOB.



Book the meeting

Not the opener's job. That is the whole call's job.



Qualify the prospect

Not yet. Nobody answers qualifying questions from a stranger.



Deliver the pitch

Cramming it into the first breath is why they hang up.



Buy twenty seconds

The entire job. Everything in this guide serves it.

Holding that spec prevents the most common failure: cramming the reason for calling, the value proposition and the ask into the first breath because you are afraid of being cut off. Prospects hang up on sellers who sound like they are racing a clock. They stay on the line for people who sound unhurried.

300 leads. 8 providers. One verifier.

Every provider enriched the same leads on the same day. Every returned email was checked by a third party.



SHARED BY
Jed Mahrle

94.0 Prospero Global Score 1st of 8 tools	97% Pass the inbox check 181 of 187 returned	60% Valid emails found 181 of 300 leads	100% Mobile numbers found 50 of 50 checked
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Metric	 APOLLO	 SEAMLESS	 PROSPEO	 LUSHA	 LEADMAGIC	 HUNTER	 ICYPEAS	 ROCKETREACH
Global Score Coverage, deliverability and price in one number	72.3	76.3	 94.0	69.1	75.2	57.7	52.1	34.3
Deliverability Of what it declared valid, how much lands	88% 209 / 237	97% 182 / 187	97% 181 / 187	79% 172 / 218	95% 131 / 138	98% 97 / 99	98% 60 / 61	79% 49 / 62
Valid emails found Verified deliverable, out of 300	70% 209 emails	61% 182 emails	60% 181 emails	57% 172 emails	44% 131 emails	32% 97 emails	20% 60 emails	16% 49 emails
Dead emails shipped Sold as valid, failed verification	28	5	6	46	7	2	1	13
Mobile coverage Numbers found on the same leads	n/a	72% 36 / 50	100% 50 / 50	76% 38 / 50	84% 42 / 50	n/a	n/a	n/a
Price per 1,000 emails List price at \$3,000 a year	\$14	n/a	\$5	\$78	\$9	\$8	\$7	\$75
Price per 1,000 mobiles List price at \$3,000 a year	\$70	n/a	\$55	\$389	\$90	n/a	n/a	\$75
Metrics led	1	0	3	0	0	1	1	0

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An email counts only when the provider itself declared it valid and BounceBan independently confirmed it deliverable; catch-all and guessed addresses never count. Global Score weights: coverage 40%, deliverability 30%, price 15%, mobile 15%, fixed before scoring and identical for every tool. Full report, examples and summary: prospero.io/benchmark | 1st August 2026

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Eleven sections, thirteen pages

9

Scripts, word for word, each with when it fits and when it fails.

3

Tiers, ordered by preparation: none, one segment insight, per-prospect research.

1

Worksheet that sets the A/B test up before the first dial.

14

Ways to lose the call in the first ten seconds. Audit yourself.

01	The only job an opener has	It buys twenty seconds. Nothing more	02
02	Why Prospeo	The dial list under every opener, and the offer	03
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SECTION 02

A mediocre opener said calmly beats a perfect one said anxiously

This is the part most opener lists skip, and it matters more than any script in this document. The words are the smaller half.

WHAT GOOD SOUNDS LIKE

**Slower than feels natural**

With real pauses rather than filled ones. The pace that feels too slow to you sounds normal to them.

**Downward inflection**

Upward inflection at the end of a statement turns it into a question, and questions sound like asking permission.

**No apology in the voice**

Not in the words and not in the tone. Apologising for calling confirms you should not have called.

**No performed enthusiasm**

Brightness that is not really there reads as a script, and a script is the thing they are listening for.

HOW TO FIX IT IN TWO WEEKS

01

Record your calls

All of them, for a week. Listen only for how you sound to somebody who does not know you.

02

Mark where you sound like a seller

Note the exact moments. There will be a pattern, and it is almost always pace.

03

Find someone to imitate

A phone manner you admire. Listen to how they hold silence, then copy it deliberately.

04

Record again and compare

The change is gradual and then obvious. Two weeks is enough to hear it.

05

Ask someone else to listen

Somebody who has never cold called will tell you in ten seconds whether you sound like a person.

You are two adults working out whether there is a fit. You are not begging for time and you are not beneath them.

Newer sellers calling senior titles need this most: your advantage is not seniority, it is pattern recognition. They see one company. You see what is happening across dozens of similar ones. That is a legitimate reason to be on the phone, and it should be audible.

SECTION 03 / TIER ONE

Three openers that need no preparation at all

These work on any tightly segmented list without researching the individual. If your list is uniform enough that one reason for calling fits everyone on it, run these at volume.

TIER ONE · NO PREP

Run at volume today on any tightly segmented list.

TIER TWO · 10 MIN PER SEGMENT

One insight covers a hundred calls. Page 07.

TIER THREE · 2-3 MIN PER PROSPECT

Reserve for accounts worth the time. Page 08.

01 The honest cold call

CANDOUR

“Hi [NAME], it’s [YOUR NAME] from [COMPANY]. I’ll be upfront, this is a cold call. Can I take thirty seconds to tell you why I’m calling?”

Variants: “I know I’ve caught you out of the blue, is now a terrible time?” · “You weren’t expecting my call, but can I steal thirty seconds?”

WHY IT WORKS

Naming the call for what it is disarms them precisely because they were braced for a seller pretending otherwise. The thirty-second ask is small enough to grant.

WHEN IT FITS

Sellers who can deliver candour without apologising for it. Markets where directness reads as respect rather than bluntness.

WHEN IT FAILS

Delivered nervously it just confirms their instinct to hang up. The wrong move is half-doing it: naming it, then sounding sorry.

02 Direct, with a disarming question

FASTEST TO THE POINT

“Hey [NAME], it’s [YOUR NAME] with [COMPANY].” *(pause, let them respond)* “I’m calling about [TOPIC]. If you don’t mind me asking, do you still handle that, or am I completely lost?”

WHY IT WORKS

“Or am I completely lost?” assumes you might be wrong, which removes the pressure. Once they confirm, they have asked you a question, far warmer than pushing past “what is this about?”

WHEN IT FITS

Time-pressed prospects, transactional motions, and sellers who would rather get to the point than warm up.

WHEN IT FAILS

If you cannot name a specific topic. “I’m calling about sales” is not a topic and they will hear that immediately.

03 Problem first

NEVER MENTIONS YOU

“Hey [NAME], quick one and then I’ll get out of your way. Most [JOB TITLE]s I speak to at [COMPANY SIZE] companies are dealing with [SPECIFIC PROBLEM] right now. Is that landing anywhere near you, or are you in better shape than most?”

WHY IT WORKS

It never mentions you until they have engaged. The closing question is binary and slightly flattering, easy to answer either way, and a genuine no is useful in ten seconds.

WHEN IT FITS

Lists so tightly segmented that one problem genuinely applies to every single person on them.

WHEN IT FAILS

If the problem is generic. The test: would they think that is me, or that is everyone? “Compliance is hard” gets a brush-off.

SECTION 04 / TIER TWO

Three openers that need one piece of context

These need something true of the whole list rather than the individual. Ten minutes of preparation covers a hundred calls, which makes them the best return on time in the document.

TIER ONE · NO PREP

Run at volume today. Page 06.

TIER TWO · 10 MIN PER SEGMENT

Something true of the whole list, not the individual.
The best return on time in the document.

TIER THREE · 2-3 MIN PER PROSPECT

Reserve for accounts worth the time. Page 08.

04 Permission-based, relevance first

CURIOSITY GAP

"Hey [NAME], I was just taking a look at [THEIR WEBSITE / PROFILE / JOB AD] and had a question for you. It's [YOUR NAME] over at [COMPANY]. Have you got a moment to help me out?"

WHY IT WORKS

Mentioning a question without asking it creates a gap people stay on the line to close. Asking permission is less risky than it feels, and being granted it makes the rest of the call smoother.

WHEN IT FITS

Relationship-driven motions, and sellers who lean conversational rather than transactional.

WHEN IT FAILS

When the thing you looked at is obviously generic. If it could be said to anyone in the segment, use opener 03 and stop pretending.

05 The segment hypothesis

YOU CARRY INFORMATION

"Hi [NAME], [YOUR NAME] here from [COMPANY]. I've spent the last month speaking to [JOB TITLE]s at [SEGMENT] companies, and there's a pattern I keep hearing that I wanted to check with you. Have you got sixty seconds?"

WHY IT WORKS

It positions you as someone carrying information rather than asking for something, which inverts the usual dynamic. Senior people are chronically curious about what their peers are doing.

WHEN IT FITS

Senior titles, and any market where the buyer is isolated from peers doing the same job.

WHEN IT FAILS

If you have not actually done the calls. You must be able to say what the pattern is when they ask, and they will ask.

06 Peer reference

PROXIMITY

"Hey [NAME], [YOUR NAME] from [COMPANY]. We've been doing some work with [COMPARABLE COMPANY] on [PROBLEM], and your name came up as someone in a similar spot. Fair to give you thirty seconds on why, or have I got the wrong end of it?"

WHY IT WORKS

Proximity lowers the "who is this random person" reflex. A named comparable, or an honest description where you cannot name one, gives instant context for why the call exists at all.

WHEN IT FITS

Markets where you have real customers who genuinely look like the prospect you are calling.

WHEN IT FAILS

The moment you overstate it. "Your name came up" must be true or defensibly true, or you have opened with a lie they can smell.

SECTION 05 / TIER THREE

Three openers worth two minutes of research each

Reserve these for accounts that justify the time. What makes them work is not the research itself, it is the bridge from what you found to the problem it tends to create.

TIER ONE · NO PREP Run at volume today. Page 06.	TIER TWO · 10 MIN PER SEGMENT One insight, a hundred calls. Page 07.	TIER THREE · 2-3 MIN PER PROSPECT What makes these work is not the research, it is the bridge from what you found to the problem it creates.
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07 Signal led

BRIDGE, DO NOT STOP

"Hi [NAME], [YOUR NAME] from [COMPANY]. I saw [OBSERVABLE SIGNAL] and it made me want to call rather than email. Teams doing that usually run into [CONSEQUENCE] about a quarter later. Have you hit that yet, or has it not surfaced?"

WHY IT WORKS

The bridge in line three is the whole thing. A signal alone is flattery. A signal joined to the problem it creates is relevance, and it is the step automated tools consistently fail at.

WHEN IT FITS

Any account where a genuine catalyst or symptom exists and you can name the consequence it produces.

WHEN IT FAILS

Stopping at the signal. And never use an intent signal: saying you saw them on your website reads as surveillance and ends the call.

08 Post-touch callback

HIGHEST PERCENTAGE MOMENT

"Hi [NAME], [YOUR NAME] from [COMPANY]. I sent you something on [DAY] about [TOPIC] and figured a call would be quicker than another email. Did it land, or shall I give you the ten-second version?"

WHY IT WORKS

It is not really a cold call, which is exactly the point. It converts a sequence into a conversation, and the offer of a ten-second version is an easy yes to give.

WHEN IT FITS

Mid-sequence, and especially after a profile view or an opened email, which is the quiet signal of attention.

WHEN IT FAILS

If you did not actually send anything. There is no version of this that survives them checking.

09 Content mirror

THEIR OWN WORDS

"Hi [NAME], [YOUR NAME] from [COMPANY]. You wrote something recently about [THEIR STATED PRIORITY], and it lined up with something I keep running into. I'd rather ask you about it than pitch you anything. Two minutes?"

WHY IT WORKS

When a decision-maker publishes a priority they have handed you their language, their tone and an internal agenda item stated out loud. Mirroring it is the closest a cold call gets to being invited.

WHEN IT FITS

Prospects who post. Pairs well with a hard timing signal like active hiring: the content says what they care about, the hiring says now.

WHEN IT FAILS

If you did not read it properly. Referencing a post you skimmed is worse than not referencing it at all.

SECTION 06

Nine openers is nine hypotheses, not an answer

None of the nine is the right one. The right one is whatever works for your voice, your market and your persona, and the only way to find it is to test properly. Here is what properly means.

THE SHAPE OF THE TEST



Alternate by call, never by day, so day-of-week effects cancel out. Same list, same reason for calling, same time of day.

100

connects on opener A before you read anything into it

100

connects on opener B. Below that floor you are reading noise as signal

30s

the metric: of those who picked up, how many were still talking at thirty seconds

THE PROTOCOL, IN EIGHT RULES

01 Pick two, not nine

One from tier one and one from tier two. Testing nine at once produces noise you cannot read.

02 Isolate one variable

Change the opener and nothing else. Same list, same reason for calling, same time of day.

03 Split it evenly

Fifty-fifty, alternating by call rather than by day.

04 Get to volume

A hundred connects per variant is a reasonable floor.

05 Run it two weeks

Long enough that one bad Tuesday does not decide which opener you use for the next year.

06 Measure conversation rate

Still talking after thirty seconds. Not meetings booked.

07 Declare a winner late

Only when the gap is clear and consistent, never on the first day one of them edges ahead.

08 Keep the loser

It may still be right for a specific persona or seniority. Log what you learned.

WHY THE METRIC MATTERS MORE THAN THE METHOD

Judge an opener on the stage it actually affects. Meetings booked measures everything downstream of the opener too, so a strong opener attached to a weak call will look like a weak opener, and you will change the wrong thing.

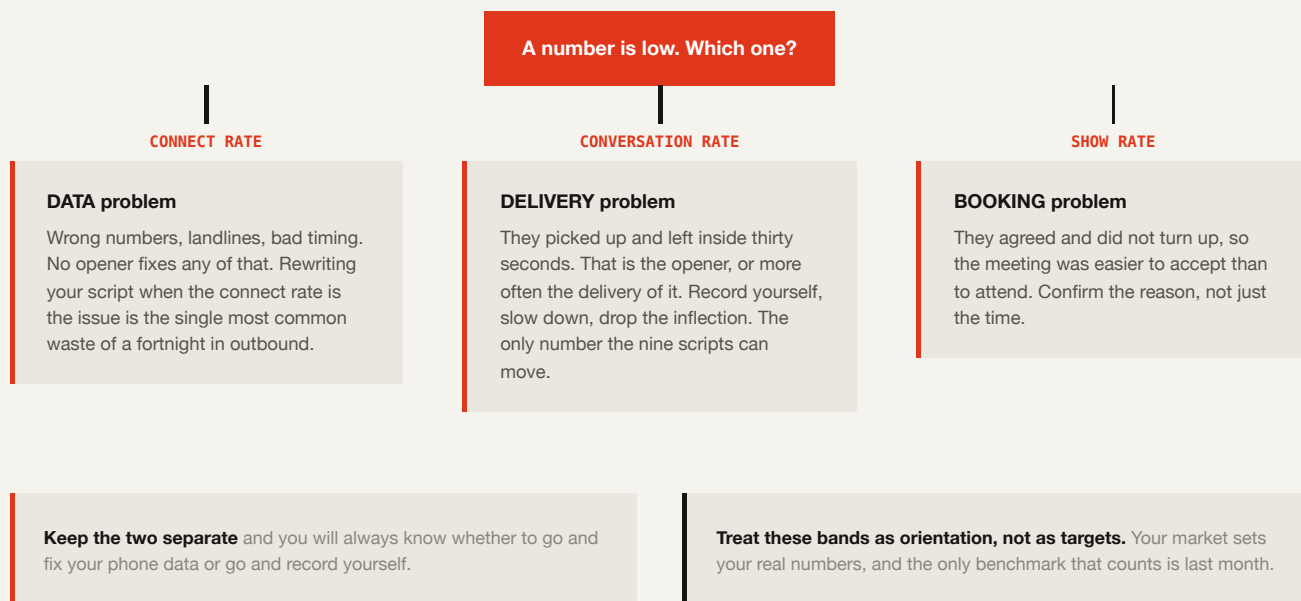
SECTION 07

Five numbers, and the one that tells you where the problem is

Before you rewrite a script, find out whether the script is what is broken. Most of the time it is not, and the difference is visible in these five numbers.

	NEEDS WORK	SOLID	STRONG
Connect rate, verified mobiles	Under 15%	15–25%	Above 25%
Connect rate, mixed list	Under 8%	8–12%	Above 12%
Conversation to meeting	Under 15%	15–25%	Above 25%
Meetings per 100 dials	Under 1	1–2	Above 2
Meeting show rate	Under 70%	70–85%	Above 85%

WHERE TO LOOK WHEN A NUMBER SITS IN THE NEEDS-WORK BAND



WORKSHEET

Set the test up before you make the first dial

Fill this in, then do not change anything on it for two weeks. Every field you leave blank is a way the result can be explained away afterwards.

THE TWO YOU ARE TESTING

OPENER A

Which one, and from which tier

OPENER B

One from a different tier, so the comparison teaches you something

THE ONE VARIABLE

The opener only. Write down what you are holding constant

HOLD THESE CONSTANT

THE LIST

One segment. If the list changes mid-test the result means nothing

REASON FOR CALLING

The same topic or problem for both openers

TIME OF DAY

And alternate A and B by call, never by day

WHAT YOU ARE COUNTING

CONNECTS, A / B

Target one hundred each before you read anything into it

STILL TALKING AT 30S

The number that decides it. Conversation rate, not meetings

START AND END DATE

Two weeks minimum. Write the end date down now

AND WHAT YOU FOUND

WINNER

And by how much. A small gap is not a winner

WHO IT WORKED ON

Seniority, segment, time of day. The loser may still own one of these

NEXT VARIABLE

One thing, next fortnight. Not the opener again

BEFORE YOU DECLARE A WINNER

Ask one question: is the gap big enough and consistent enough that you would bet next quarter on it? If the honest answer is no, you have not finished the test. Keep dialling rather than deciding.

SECTION 09

Fourteen ways to lose the call in the first ten seconds

Read this as an audit of your own calls rather than a list of things other people do. Most sellers are doing three of these and have never heard themselves do any of them.

14

Ways to lose the call in the first ten seconds, listed below.

3

How many are true of the average seller who has never heard their own calls.

10

Calls to listen back to before you tick the boxes honestly.

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Opening with your name and company. They spend your first ten seconds working out whether they should know you | ☐ Claiming to have looked at something. When you did not look at it. They will ask what you saw |
| ☐ Cramming everything into the first breath. The reason, the pitch and the ask, because you are afraid of being cut off | ☐ Referencing an intent signal. A website visit or an email open reads as surveillance and ends the call |
| ☐ Speaking too fast. The single most common tell, and the one thing that undermines every script here | ☐ Mentioning a trigger and stopping. A signal without the consequence it creates is flattery, not relevance |
| ☐ Upward inflection on statements. Turns your opener into a request for permission you did not mean to make | ☐ Overstating a peer connection. "Your name came up" has to be true, or you have opened with a lie |
| ☐ Apologising for calling. In the words or in the tone. Either one confirms you should not have called | ☐ Switching openers every day. Based on how the last call felt, rather than on any evidence at all |
| ☐ A generic problem in opener 03. The mechanism needs them thinking that is me, not that is everyone | ☐ Testing nine at once. Produces noise, and you learn nothing you can repeat next quarter |
| ☐ Judging on meetings booked. That measures the whole call, not the first thirty seconds | ☐ Rewriting the script when connect rate is low. That is a data problem. No opener has ever fixed a wrong phone number |

THE ONLY WAY TO FIND YOURS

You cannot hear these while you are making the call. Record a week, listen to ten, and tick the boxes above honestly. Three will be true of you, and fixing those three is worth more than any new script.

WHERE TO START

One opener, one list, one number

Not nine openers and a testing programme. Pick one thing to change this week, and give yourself something measurable at the end of it.

MON	MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	WEEK 2
Record ten calls	Find your pattern	Pick one tier-one opener	Slow down, drop the inflection	Add a tier-two opener	Count conversations	Read the result honestly
Do not change anything yet. Know how you currently sound first.	Tick the boxes on the previous page. It is almost always pace.	No research needed. Learn it well enough to stop reading it.	Two changes only. Delivery moves the number faster than words.	Ten minutes of prep, then alternate A and B call by call.	Still talking after thirty seconds. Write the two numbers down.	A hundred connects each. If the gap is not obvious, keep dialling.

Teach it to one other person

Explaining why the opener works is the fastest way to find the part of it you do not actually understand yet.

Keep the losing opener

It may be right for a different seniority or segment. Write down who it worked on rather than deleting it and starting again next quarter.

Then change one thing again

Same protocol, next variable: the reason for calling, the time of day, the list. One at a time is slower for a fortnight and far faster over a year.

BEFORE ANY OF IT WORKS, THE NUMBER HAS TO RING

Verified mobile data moves the connect band from 8–12% to 15–25%, which is what gets an A/B test to a readable sample inside a fortnight. Prospeo is \$55 per 1,000 mobiles on a yearly plan, seven times less than the priciest provider in the same independent test.

THE OFFER

50%

off your first year

Annual plans are half price right now, which makes this the cheapest year it will cost to dial a verified list.